schemes often end up being counter-productive. Threat perceptions appear to be in play behind certain actions and counteractions at the Myanmar–Bangladesh border as well. It is important that this cognitive play in decision-making is recognized and addressed accordingly (Karakul and Qudrat-Ullah 2008, p. 3).

The domestic view of threat, on the other hand, tends to regard inbound people (that is, immigrants from other countries) as potential sources of problems and conflict (Werz and Conley 2012, pp. 2–3). Thus the borders also find a prominent place in this threat narrative. However, it must be remembered that, in themselves, borders are man-made — 'drawn' rather than 'created' — and hence are subject to debate and prone to violation.

Identifiable threats along the Bangladesh–Myanmar border include social and sociopolitical threats to territory. The two countries share a few threats — un-demarcated land boundaries and cross-border movements by insurgents, for example — where coordination and cooperation is generally easier (evident by the success in maritime boundary delimitation in 2012 or in launching combing operations to support each other along the border). But some threats are more severe for one side than the other — for example, the Rohingya influx, or drug trafficking; issues that arguably affect Bangladesh more than Myanmar. In such cases, appropriate identification of the threat as well as a sympathetic understanding of the mutual value in cooperatively addressing the threat becomes important.

How do the security systems of Myanmar and Bangladesh locate, and deal with, such threats? In addressing this question, the following section will draw from the recent history of conflicts in the region but will restrict itself to bilateral affairs only. Discussion of security related to any third country — for example, the growing Indo–Myanmar military relations and its attendant security impact on Bangladesh — is not included.

Threat perception in Myanmar

In maintaining its western gateway with Bangladesh, Myanmar seems to employ an enhanced level of security and often resorts to unusual levels of action or counteraction, not all of which appear to be well planned. Some observers maintain that the 2008 crisis between Myanmar and Bangladesh might have been an outcome of unintended actions by Myanmar, which were followed by equally unprecedented countermoves (in the form of troop deployment) by Bangladesh.[6]